

Lawsuit hints at source in text scandal

Ex-publicist to actor Baldoni denies being involved in actions against co-star Lively.

By Matt Hamilton

When actress Blake Lively went public this month with the explosive accusation that her “It Ends With Us” co-star and producer Justin Baldoni and his team developed a campaign to “smear” her in the press for reporting on-set sexual harassment, she marshaled powerful evidence: her opponents’ own words.

A trove of text messages Lively submitted to California’s Civil Rights Department appeared to show Baldoni, his production company and two publicists affiliated with the company plotting “social manipulation,” among other tactics, to fend off any airing of Lively’s grievances and preserve Baldoni’s reputation.

“All of this will be most importantly untraceable,” Melissa Nathan, one of the crisis publicists, said in a text.

The text messages — rife with bravado, boasts and intrigue — have fueled a scandal that has rocked the entertainment industry and spotlighted the ruthless underbelly of the Hollywood publicity machine.

Baldoni’s attorney, Bryan Freedman, has denied the existence of a smear campaign and said that the “cherry-picked correspondence” showed normal internal planning for crisis scenarios on a film that grossed more than \$350 million. Freedman said the planning came after Lively “enlisted her own representative ... to plant negative and completely fabricated and false stories with media.”

Amid the damaging revelations, one question has stood out: How did Lively and her team obtain the candid, private chats of Baldoni’s public relations team?

The answer in part shows the tangled web of personalities and businesses drawn into the dispute, and the confluence of legal and public relations strategies at play.

“I’ve never seen a case like this,” said Neville Johnson, the veteran entertainment litigator who has represented actors, musicians and other artists for nearly 50 years. Calling it “modern warfare in law,” Johnson was [See **Hollywood**, A7]



AL SEIB For The Times

“WE HAVE a responsibility to deliver clean,” said Thomas Martin, co-founder and CEO of cannabis grower Raw Garden.

LEGAL WEED, BROKEN PROMISES

Untested pesticides in pot brands

For Santa Cruz County cannabis farmers battling infestations of aphids, one chemical in particular worked wonders. Those in the know were effusive in their praise of pymetrozine to save their high-dollar weed crops from the destructive, sap-sucking bugs.

A strong formulation of the pesticide worked “very, very well on aphids and root aphids, which were massive issues,” said Scott Eaton, cultivation manager for a farm that reported applying the pesticide 76 times from 2021 to 2022 after learning about it from other growers in the farming valley.

“We were all communicating with each other about how great it was,” he said.

There was one major problem.

The use of pymetrozine on cannabis is illegal in California.

California fails to monitor for a host of chemicals pervading the state’s cannabis supply chain

By Paige St. John

Treating cannabis crops with prohibited chemicals such as pymetrozine has become so casual that The Times found farms including these applications in their monthly pesticide use reports to the state. There is no evidence that state regulators or county agriculture departments routinely take note or act on these reports.

The overlooked practice is among a number of faults in California’s farm-to-dispensary cannabis supply chain, with troubling consequences for the state’s \$5-billion legal cannabis market and serious health risks to its consumers.

More than half of cannabis smoking products in California’s legal market contain chemicals for which there is no public safety [See **Cannabis**, A8]

A killer’s new beginning, courtesy of a stranger



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

NANCY ADAMS gained an unlikely housemate after she volunteered for the nonprofit Homecoming Project, which places former inmates in private homes.

Nicholas Nabors was struggling after 29 years behind bars — until she took him in.

By Doug Smith

Nancy Adams grew comfortable sharing her Compton townhome during the COVID-19 crisis, when she rented spare bedrooms to traveling nurses.

Still, it was a long leap of faith to open her home to her current houseguest — a paroled murderer.

Adams, 72, had retired from a career in banking but still relishes her backup job, tending bar at Crypto.com Arena.

“I try to keep it exciting,” she said. “What’s the point of waking up?”

But it was something

deeper — a mixture of Christian faith, a familial experience with incarceration, a touch of loneliness — that drew her to the post on social media seeking homes for former inmates.

“The thought of what I had read wouldn’t leave me alone,” she said.

After mulling it over for a week, Adams responded. In October, she became a host for the Homecoming Project, a reentry program that turns private homes into transitional housing for men and women during their first year out of prison.

Adams, who had accepted her brother back into her home after more than a decade of estrangement and cared for him through his final years, was intuitively aligned with the mission.

“This is a great thing,” she said. “They didn’t have [See **Homecoming**, A16]

TikTok? Trump says he’ll handle it

The president-elect wants the high court to step aside and let him make a deal. **PERSPECTIVES**, A2

A warning not to shield migrants

Atty. Gen. Bonta calls letters targeting sanctuary policies a “scare tactic.” **CALIFORNIA**, B1

Weather

Partly sunny; cool. L.A. Basin: 62/48. **B8**

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Climate change threatening California piers

By Noah Haggerty

As a series of winter storms slammed California’s coast with powerful rip currents and towering waves, part of the Santa Cruz Wharf collapsed on Monday, plunging two contractors and a city employee into the water.

The pier was one of several public wharves and piers in the state actively

undergoing structural integrity upgrades.

While the coastal structures have occasionally succumbed to the ocean’s power throughout the years (including the Santa Monica Pier, once while the mayor was standing on it), the aging structures now face increasingly dynamic and unpredictable storms and often expensive and delayed upgrade projects.

“We have exposed infra-

structure across the entire California coast, and it’s going to be ... stressed by the impacts of climate change, whether it’s changes in storm patterns, frequency and magnitude or sea level,” said Patrick Barnard, research director for the Climate Impacts and Coastal Processes Team at the U.S. Geological Survey.

At least 10 of the state’s dozens of coastal public piers were closed for part or

all of 2024 due to structural damage sustained in winter storms over the last two years. At least five more have longer-term upgrade plans to address structural issues.

In 2018, a structural analysis of San Diego’s Ocean Beach Pier found the best option to address ongoing expensive repair needs and rising sea levels was to replace the pier. In late 2023, violent winter storms wal-

[See **Piers**, A6]



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